architectural footprint in this region – more than the Ghaznavids' plundering raids – that irreversibly ushered the entire Indian subcontinent into the Persianate world, and as one of the principal *loci* wherein Persianate cultural production not only thrived, its practitioners also engaged with Indic linguistic–cultural ambits for the following millennium.

These astounding successes – perhaps especially noteworthy for "outsiders" like the Saljuqs and Shansabanis – all underscore mobility, the third proposed sphere of activity of Perso-Islamic prestige cultures, which made kingship accessible for ambitious newcomers to the Persianate ecumene. It might appear evident that the Saljuqs' and the Shansabanis' origins within nomadic and transhumant lifeways, respectively, and their consequent seasonal movements predisposed them to regular traversal of large distances across contiguous yet diverse eco-cultural terrains. In turn, adaptation to differing climates and topographies was a perennial feature of their lifeworlds. Furthermore, flexible and consultative community and military decision-making, and lack of investment in provisions and infrastructure might have made nomad armies less reliable (see below), but, on the other hand, the net positives were their virtually nil "operating expenses," agility, and quick recovery from defeats. Arguably, all of these lived experiences coalesced into a form of "cultural capital," enabling the expansive imperial formations they managed to create across diverse landscapes.[52]

As noted above, the Yamini–Ghaznavids also conducted annual campaigns for plunder deep into the north Indian *duab* throughout the first half of the eleventh century, the later sultans reinitiating them for a time during the century's last decades.[53] Although the Ghaznavids ostensibly adhered to a sedentist and overall more traditional courtly model, their India campaigns in particular could have nonetheless combined "military purposes and seasonal migrations."[54] However, the Ghaznavids never achieved a north Indian footprint akin to that of the Shansabanis, whose "cultural capital" at least in part allowed them to succeed where the Ghaznavids had not. In light of the historical trajectories and territorial expansions of both the Saljuqs and the Shansabanis within the Persianate world, it would seem that true mobility – *without* the rigidity and expense of reigning courtly cultures – acquired a new significance for Perso-Islamic kingship during the twelfth century.

Integrating Sources: A History of the Early Shansabanis

With a cognizance of the spheres of activity making it possible for newcomers to the Persianate world to access kingship – specifically Perso-Islamic kingship – we might more credulously envision the rapid rise to elite status of a previously unknown group of Ghuris from central Afghanistan's nomad–urban continuum to become the Shansabanis of